

Where We Align

Preetoshi × Rahul — Team DNA Design Sync

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This is a distilled record of our conversation, focused on the decisions and shared convictions that should guide what we build next. Not a transcript rehash — a working document.

The Core Philosophical Shifts

These are the "why" decisions. They should steer everything downstream — what we prototype, how we pitch it, and what we push back on.

1. Insight-first, not metric-first

The Big Five scores (openness, agreeableness, etc.) are real and important — but they're the *source* of the insight, not the headline. Nobody opens Team DNA wanting to know their agreeableness percentile. They want to know: *how do I work well with this person?*

Preetoshi pushed this framing: lead with what Team DNA teaches you — tangible, human, actionable observations — and let the underlying trait data live beneath as the authority behind those insights. The sentence on the right side of a comparison (e.g., "you both are open — use it, agree out loud, divide the work") is the valuable thing. The score is the footnote that earns trust. Rahul was sold on this — he'd moved toward metric-first because of external pressure from Sam and what Balance (competitor) does, not from conviction. This felt like a genuine alignment once it was named.

2. Multiplication, not comparison

Preetoshi raised the idea that when two people's profiles come together, the framing could be "what do you *create* together" — not "how do you stack up." Even visually: the symbol might feel like × (times), not + (addition) or vs. A combined bloom can accidentally feel like a judgment — "your shape is smaller." But a multiplication framing says: these two people, together, produce something neither produces alone. Rahul hadn't noticed that distinction in his own designs but found it compelling — it connects to the instinct he'd already had to remove numbers and comparative elements.

3. Differences are the point, not the problem

This one felt genuinely mutual. Rahul had already been moving this direction — removing numbers from the bloom, working with Victoria on the idea that even a smaller bloom shouldn't feel "bad." Preetoshi articulated the broader philosophy: Team DNA is about making visible what each person *is* and how that uniqueness becomes a team strength, not about optimizing toward a target. The moment it feels like a ranking, people tense up. Both feel strongly that score-like elements should be resisted. A smaller bloom isn't worse. A different shape isn't wrong.

4. Spectrums, not scores

Showing "38 out of 100 emotional range" feels like a failing grade, no matter how we dress it up. Instead, personality traits should be displayed as a spectrum with *both ends labeled positively*:

- Sensitive & vigilant ↔ Calm & resilient
- Direct & analytical ↔ Collaborative & empathetic
- Spontaneous & adaptable ↔ Structured & deliberate

This way, wherever you fall, you're reading a description of a strength — not a distance from a target. Rahul had actually explored this in earlier iterations and we converged back to it as clearly the right call. No percentages. No fill bars out of 100.

The Design Decisions

These are the specific UX choices we converged on.

Three levels, one surface

The information architecture has three natural layers, and both of us gravitated toward keeping them as one continuous space rather than tabs within tabs:

- **Team view** — The zoomed-out web of your whole team. Who's here, how they're connected.
- **Duo view** — Click into a connection between two people. Their combined archetype, insights about how they work together, things to try.
- **Individual view** — Click into a single person. Their profile, their bloom, their spectrum traits.

Preetoshi feels like navigation between these could feel spatial — zooming in and out of the same thing rather than jumping between pages, using animation as a storytelling device to show you're going *into* a relationship or a person. Rahul is sold on the experience overall and likes the

idea of the three levels, though his focus is more on how this fits into the existing product and whether it can actually get built.

Two views for team navigation

Preetoshi explored a **web visualization** (people in a circle, connection lines between them) — it's human-centric, you start with faces, you click connections. Rahul had independently explored a **scrollable/list view** where you select people to compare, partly because he'd already been thinking about scale.

Rahul's push on scalability is important: the web breaks at 12–15 people. The scrollable view handles any team size and could even contain the web as a visual element within it for smaller groups. Preetoshi likes the idea of building both and auto-switching based on team size, but if anything the scalable view might be the more important one to build first since it works universally and can house the other. We need to be mindful of the deadline — the scalable view is the safer bet if we have to pick one.

Deliver value directly — don't make people dig for it

Rahul's "Things to Try" feature pointed at something we both feel strongly about: Team DNA should give you something immediately useful without requiring you to sift through data and draw your own conclusions. The experience should do the interpretive work for you. Whether that takes the form of actionable suggestions, a narrative insight, or a direct action (like scheduling a 1:1) — the principle is the same: the user should receive value, not perform analysis.

Where metrics live vs. where insights live

Preetoshi feels like detailed trait metrics (the Big Five spectrums, the bloom shape) might belong most naturally in the **individual profile** — that's where you're learning about yourself, and the specificity feels earned. The **team view** could also be a reasonable home for metrics at a higher altitude — seeing where everyone sits on a spectrum, collective strengths and ranges. But the **duo view** should probably lead with synthesized insights and actionable observations, not trait-by-trait comparisons. Rahul resonated with this — he pointed out that showing "six things" (the overall plus all five traits) in a duo view risks overwhelming people without justifying why each one is there.

This is still an open question worth sitting with: for each view, what is the most meaningful, most interesting, most curiosity-satisfying information to surface? The principle feels right (insights over metrics, with metrics accessible deeper), but the specific content at each level needs deliberate thought.

Empty and partial states need real design attention

Rahul raised this: what does Team DNA look like when only 3 of 8 people have completed the assessment? This isn't an edge case — it's likely the *most common* state for the first few weeks. The experience needs to be compelling even when incomplete, and the nudges to get the rest of the team to participate need to feel inviting, not nagging.

Ideas Worth Exploring

These came up in conversation as possibilities we're both intrigued by but aren't treating as core decisions yet. They're secondary to the main experience design, but any of them could become meaningful if there's room.

The assessment as a learning experience. Right now the Big Five assessment is a chore you complete to unlock results. There could be potential for it to deliver value in real time — your bloom shifting as you answer, micro-insights between questions. The assessment is already a known thing (Big Five), so we're not reinventing it — but there's real room to innovate on the experience of taking it. Secondary priority for now, since sorting through the results experience matters more.

A narrative/guided experience. Rather than dumping all data on a page, what if Team DNA had a walkthrough feel — something closer to "Spotify Wrapped for your team"? A curated, story-like reveal of what your team is and how relationships work. This is a side idea, not the core direction, but it resonates with the anti-dashboard philosophy.

Cross-team visibility. Could you search for and explore people outside your team? A manager pairing people from different teams, or anyone curious about a cross-functional collaborator. Team is the home base, but maybe it's not a wall.

Things to Navigate Carefully

The design system tension

Sergei and May want Team DNA to fit the existing design system. Both of us feel that if the design system constrains good UX, then the design system needs to grow — not the design. Pragmatically: we can align on typography, color tokens, and visual language while potentially introducing new interaction patterns. Preetoshi feels like if a bespoke pattern proves its value, it earns its place in the system. Rahul agrees in principle but is also thinking about what engineers

will actually want to build — and whether the prototype can be compelling enough to justify a new pattern.

The "team" concept doesn't exist in the product yet

This is Rahul's ongoing battle: there's no first-class concept of "team" in the platform that lets users create and manage their own teams. Without it, Team DNA is built on a shaky foundation — the data gets consolidated from individual assessments rather than being genuinely team-structured. Engineers agree this needs to be built first. Sam disagrees. This fight isn't resolved and it matters.

Stakeholder fragmentation

Rahul's experience with Team Pulse is a warning: the initial prototype was good, then legal, other teams, and shifting PM priorities chopped it down to something much less than what was designed. The strategy this time should be to minimize dependencies on other teams (assessment team, Grow team, legal) by being smart about scope, and to have a prototype compelling enough to survive the gauntlet.

Don't share half-baked work too early

We both agreed: showing rough explorations in a group meeting invites opinions that bias the work before it has a chance to prove itself as a vision. Build the interactive prototype first. Make it feel real. Then present it as a direction, not a sketch.

Meta-Alignments: The Bigger Picture

These aren't Team DNA design decisions — they're shared observations about the organizational dynamics that shape what we can build and how. Worth naming because they inform our strategy.

The product is sales-driven when it should be product-driven

We both feel the platform is increasingly optimized for partner demos and sales narratives rather than actual user value. Features become "nice screenshots to look at for the partners" rather than experiences good enough to sell themselves. The Team Pulse qualitative data got cut not because it was bad for users, but because HR partners cared more about measurement. That pattern will repeat with Team DNA if we're not careful.

Small company acting like a big company

Rahul put it plainly: BetterUp has the organizational complexity of a large company without the resources to justify it. Shipping anything requires talking to 10 different stakeholders — the

assessment team, the Grow team, legal, the growth team. His team pulse prototype was chopped down through this process. Preetoshi sees the same pattern from a different angle — the PRD, for instance, is well-organized but potentially overengineered for what is fundamentally a simple thing. The best section was the user needs *without* the prescribed solutions.

Betas become permanent — so start right

Rahul's experience is that once something ships at BetterUp, the company rarely goes back to improve it. Preetoshi's framing: people add, they don't subtract. So whatever we launch will accumulate features on top of it. Starting simple matters more than it normally would — if the foundation is wrong, it compounds.

Dashboard fatigue across the product

The platform is deeply dashboard-oriented. Preetoshi described this as "tabs within tabs, pages within pages" — every new feature adds another surface, and the more caged surfaces there are, the less powerful any individual one feels. Rahul agrees and has experienced this firsthand with Team Pulse. Both of us feel Team DNA would benefit from resisting the dashboard pattern. This is partly why the experiential/narrative ideas resonate — they'd be a genuinely different mode of interacting with the product.

AI should be contextual, not contained

Grow (the AI coach) lives in a separate tab. Both of us feel that AI should be "braided" into experiences — available wherever you are, aware of your context — not something you navigate away to use. If you're looking at your duo view with a teammate and you have a question, you should be able to ask it right there. This is a platform-level conviction, not just a Team DNA feature request. For MVP, at minimum a contextual link to Grow pre-loaded with Team DNA context is better than the current separation.

Team Pulse and Team DNA could be one surface

Preetoshi brought this up and Rahul immediately said that's where he'd been going too — both feel these shouldn't be separate tabs. They're both about understanding your team — one through personality data, the other through periodic check-ins. Combining them into a unified "team" experience would reduce surface sprawl and make both features stronger. Rahul has fought this battle before and lost badly. It may not happen for this version, but it's a shared conviction about the right long-term direction.

Sergei's role matters

Sergei (new design lead) has strong craft values — Preetoshi was struck by his subtractive thinking and focus over chaos. Rahul likes him as a designer and design lead but feels the gap right now is organizational advocacy — the design team needs someone who will push back on product development processes that sideline user experience, not just improve how designers

work with each other. Preetoshi doesn't know Sergei well enough to judge the political dimension yet. Whether Sergei steps into that role or stays craft-focused is an open question that affects what's possible.

What We're Building Next

- **Preetoshi:** Build an interactive coded prototype (likely by tomorrow evening) that synthesizes the ideas from this conversation — the web view, the duo transition, the insight-first layout. Put it on GitHub so Rahul can branch and contribute.
 - **Rahul:** Share the existing codebase (zip from AWS Amplify). Push for the "team" concept in the next meeting with engineering/Sam. Ground the prototype in scalability and design system realities.
 - **Together:** Reconvene tomorrow (possibly in-office) to review the prototype and decide what's ready to share more broadly.
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A Note on How We Work

This conversation surfaced a productive dynamic worth naming: Preetoshi pushes toward the ideal experience from first principles — what should this *feel* like for the user? Rahul grounds that in what can actually ship — what are the real constraints, how do we win the political battles, how does this fit into a product that already exists?

Neither impulse alone produces the right thing. Both together got us to a stronger place than either of us had alone. That's worth protecting as this project moves forward.